Chapter-1 Introductio to Electrostatics Problem Solutions

Diego Juarez

April 2026

Contents

1 Problem 1.1 **3**
1.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
1.2 Solution . . . . . .

2 Problem 1.24 **5**
2.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
2.2 Solution . . . . . .

3 Problem 1.2 **7**
3.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
3.2 Solution . . . . . .

4 Problem 1.23 **8**
4.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
4.2 Solution . . . . . .

5 Problem 1.3 **12**
5.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
5.2 Solution . . . . . .

6 Problem 1.22 **16**
6.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
6.2 Solution . . . . . .

7 Problem 1.4 **20**
7.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
7.2 Solution . . . . . .

8 Problem 1.21 **25**
8.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
8.2 Solution . . . . . .

9 Problem 1.5 **29**
9.1 Problem Statement . . . . . .
9.2 Solution . . . . . .

1 Problem 1.1

1.1 Problem Statement

Use Gauss's theorem [and Eq. (1.21) if necessary] to prove the following:

(a) Any excess charge placed on a conductor must lie entirely on its surface. (A conductor by definition contains charges capable of moving freely under the action of applied electric fields.)

(b) A closed, hollow conductor shields its interior from fields due to charges outside, but does not shield its exterior from the fields due to charges placed inside it.

(c) The electric field at the surface of a conductor is normal to the surface and has a magnitude σ/ε_0, where σ is the charge density per unit area on the surface.

1.2 Solution

Physical principles

A conductor contains free charges. If an electric field existed inside the conducting material, these charges would feel a force

$$\mathbf{F} = q\mathbf{E},$$

and they would move. But in electrostatic equilibrium no macroscopic motion of charge occurs. Therefore the electric field inside the conductor must vanish:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E} = 0 \quad \text{inside the conducting material.}}$$

This immediately implies that the potential is constant throughout the conductor. Indeed, using

$$V(\mathbf{b}) - V(\mathbf{a}) = -\int_{\mathbf{a}}^{\mathbf{b}} \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{l},$$

if $\mathbf{E} = 0$ everywhere inside the conductor, then

$$V(\mathbf{b}) - V(\mathbf{a}) = 0.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{V = \text{constant throughout the conductor.}}$$

(a) Excess charge resides on the surface

Take any closed Gaussian surface S lying entirely within the conducting material. Since the conductor is in electrostatic equilibrium,

$$\mathbf{E} = 0 \quad \text{everywhere on } S.$$

Therefore the flux through S is

$$\oint_S \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = 0.$$

By Gauss's law,

$$\oint_S \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = \frac{Q_{\text{enc}}}{\varepsilon_0},$$

so

$$\frac{Q_{\text{enc}}}{\varepsilon_0} = 0 \qquad \Rightarrow \qquad Q_{\text{enc}} = 0.$$

Thus any closed surface taken entirely inside the conductor encloses zero net charge.

Suppose, for contradiction, that some excess charge were located somewhere in the interior of the conductor. Then one could draw a Gaussian surface entirely inside the conductor that encloses that excess charge. But Gauss's law would then require $Q_{\text{enc}} \neq 0$, contradicting the result above. Therefore no excess charge can remain in the bulk of the conductor.

Hence

$$\boxed{\text{Any excess charge placed on a conductor lies entirely on its surface.}}$$

(b) Shielding properties of a closed hollow conductor

First consider a closed hollow conductor with an empty cavity and charges outside the conductor. Since $\mathbf{E} = 0$ in the conducting material, the conductor is at constant potential V_0. In particular, the inner surface of the cavity is also at potential V_0.

Inside the empty cavity, $\rho = 0$, so the potential satisfies Laplace's equation,

$$\nabla^2 V = 0.$$

The boundary condition on the cavity wall is

$$V = V_0 = \text{constant}.$$

A constant function $V(\mathbf{r}) = V_0$ satisfies Laplace's equation and the boundary condition, and by uniqueness this is the only solution. Therefore

$$\mathbf{E} = -\nabla V = 0 \quad \text{inside the cavity.}$$

So the cavity is shielded from outside fields:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E} = 0 \quad \text{inside the empty cavity.}}$$

Now place a charge q inside the cavity. Draw a closed Gaussian surface lying entirely in the conducting material and surrounding the cavity. Since it lies in the conductor,

$$\mathbf{E} = 0,$$

so Gauss's law gives

$$Q_{\text{enc}} = 0.$$

The enclosed charge consists of the point charge q and the induced charge Q_{inner} on the inner surface, so

$$q + Q_{\text{inner}} = 0,$$

which implies

$$\boxed{Q_{\text{inner}} = -q.}$$

If the conductor as a whole is initially neutral, then the outer surface must carry charge

$$\boxed{Q_{\text{outer}} = +q.}$$

This nonzero outer charge produces an electric field outside the conductor. Therefore the exterior is not shielded from charges inside the cavity.

(c) Field at the surface of a conductor

Suppose there were a tangential component of the electric field at the conductor surface:

$$\mathbf{E}_{\parallel} \neq 0.$$

Then a charge on the surface would feel a tangential force

$$\mathbf{F}_{\parallel} = q\mathbf{E}_{\parallel},$$

so free charges would move along the surface. But in electrostatic equilibrium this cannot happen. Hence

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}_{\parallel} = 0.}$$

Thus the electric field at the surface must be normal to the surface.

To find its magnitude, take a very small cylindrical pillbox Gaussian surface straddling the conductor surface, with top face area A just outside and bottom face area A just inside. Since the field inside the conductor is zero,

$$\Phi_{\text{bottom}} = 0.$$

The side contribution vanishes in the infinitesimal limit, and the flux through the top face is

$$\Phi_{\text{top}} = E_{\perp}^{\text{out}} A.$$

Hence

$$\oint \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = E_{\perp}^{\text{out}} A.$$

The enclosed charge is the surface charge in the pillbox:

$$Q_{\text{enc}} = \sigma A.$$

Applying Gauss's law,

$$E_{\perp}^{\text{out}} A = \frac{\sigma A}{\varepsilon_0}.$$

Canceling A gives

$$E_{\perp}^{\text{out}} = \frac{\sigma}{\varepsilon_0}.$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}_{\text{outside}} = \frac{\sigma}{\varepsilon_0} \hat{\mathbf{n}}.}$$

2 Problem 1.24

2.1 Problem Statement

Consider solution of the two-dimensional Poisson equation problem of Problem 1.21, a unit square with zero potential on the boundary and a constant unit charge density in the interior, by the technique of relaxation. Choose $h = 0.25$ so that there are nine interior sites. Use symmetry to reduce the number of needed sites to three, at $(0.25, 0.25)$, $(0.5, 0.25)$, and $(0.5, 0.5)$. With so few sites, it is easy to do the iterations with a block of paper and a pocket calculator, but suit yourself.

(a) Use the "improved grid" averaging of Problem 1.22 and the simple (Jacobian) iteration scheme, starting with $4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi = 1.0$ at all three interior sites. Do at least six iterations, preferably eight or ten.

(b) Repeat the iteration procedure with the same starting values, but using Gauss–Seidel iteration.

(c) Graph the two sets of results of each iteration versus iteration number and compare with the exact values, $4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(0.25, 0.25) = 0.5691$, $4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(0.5, 0.25) = 0.7205$, $4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(0.5, 0.5) = 0.9258$. Comment on rate of convergence and final accuracy.

2.2 Solution

Let

$$u(x, y) \equiv 4\pi\varepsilon_0\, \Phi(x, y).$$

Then Poisson's equation becomes

$$\nabla^2 u = -4\pi,$$

since the charge density is constant and equal to 1 in the interior.

With $h = 0.25$, symmetry reduces the nine interior points to the three unknowns

$$a = u(0.25, 0.25), \qquad b = u(0.5, 0.25), \qquad c = u(0.5, 0.5).$$

All boundary values are zero.

Using the improved-grid 9-point formula,

$$\frac{1}{6h^2}\Big[4\big(u_E + u_W + u_N + u_S\big) + \big(u_{NE} + u_{NW} + u_{SE} + u_{SW}\big) - 20u_0\Big] \approx \nabla^2 u,$$

and substituting $\nabla^2 u = -4\pi$, we solve for the central value:

$$u_0 = \frac{1}{5}(u_E + u_W + u_N + u_S) + \frac{1}{20}(u_{NE} + u_{NW} + u_{SE} + u_{SW}) + \frac{6\pi h^2}{5}.$$

For $h = 0.25$,

$$d \equiv \frac{6\pi h^2}{5} = \frac{3\pi}{40} \approx 0.235619449.$$

By symmetry, the three update equations are

$$a = 0.4b + 0.05c + d,$$
$$b = \frac{0.4a + 0.2c + d}{0.9},$$
$$c = 0.2a + 0.8b + d.$$

We start with

$$a^{(0)} = b^{(0)} = c^{(0)} = 1.0.$$

For Jacobi iteration,

$$a^{(n+1)} = 0.4b^{(n)} + 0.05c^{(n)} + d,$$
$$b^{(n+1)} = \frac{0.4a^{(n)} + 0.2c^{(n)} + d}{0.9},$$
$$c^{(n+1)} = 0.2a^{(n)} + 0.8b^{(n)} + d.$$

The first ten Jacobi iterations are

n	$a^{(n)}$	$b^{(n)}$	$c^{(n)}$
1	0.685619	0.928466	1.235619
2	0.668787	0.841101	1.115516
3	0.627836	0.806930	1.042258
4	0.610505	0.772450	1.006731
5	0.594936	0.756853	0.975681
6	0.587145	0.743033	0.960089
7	0.580837	0.736106	0.947475
8	0.577435	0.730499	0.940671
9	0.574853	0.727475	0.935506
10	0.573385	0.725180	0.932570

For Gauss–Seidel iteration, using the order $a \to b \to c$ in each sweep,

$$a^{(n+1)} = 0.4b^{(n)} + 0.05c^{(n)} + d,$$
$$b^{(n+1)} = \frac{0.4a^{(n+1)} + 0.2c^{(n)} + d}{0.9},$$
$$c^{(n+1)} = 0.2a^{(n+1)} + 0.8b^{(n+1)} + d.$$

The first ten Gauss–Seidel iterations are

n	$a^{(n)}$	$b^{(n)}$	$c^{(n)}$
1	0.685619	0.788741	0.998736
2	0.601553	0.742666	0.949061
3	0.580639	0.730882	0.936453
4	0.575245	0.727807	0.933913
5	0.574337	0.727228	0.933267
6	0.574183	0.727120	0.933138
7	0.574157	0.727099	0.933112
8	0.574152	0.727095	0.933107
9	0.574151	0.727095	0.933106
10	0.574151	0.727094	0.933106

The exact values given in the problem are

$$a_{\text{exact}} = 0.5691, \qquad b_{\text{exact}} = 0.7205, \qquad c_{\text{exact}} = 0.9258.$$

Thus at the tenth iteration,

$$\text{Jacobi: } (a, b, c) = (0.573385,\ 0.725180,\ 0.932570),$$
$$\text{Gauss–Seidel: } (a, b, c) = (0.574151,\ 0.727094,\ 0.933106).$$

The absolute errors relative to the exact continuum values are

$$\text{Jacobi: } (0.004285,\ 0.004680,\ 0.006770),$$
$$\text{Gauss–Seidel: } (0.005051,\ 0.006594,\ 0.007306).$$

Therefore Gauss–Seidel converges much faster to the discrete improved-grid solution, reaching near-stationarity after about five or six sweeps, whereas Jacobi converges more slowly. The limiting discrete solution is not exactly equal to the quoted exact continuum solution because the finite mesh still introduces discretization error.

3 Problem 1.2

3.1 Problem Statement

The Dirac delta function in three dimensions can be taken as the improper limit as $\alpha \to 0$ of the Gaussian function

$$D(\alpha; x, y, z) = (2\pi)^{-3/2}\alpha^{-3}\exp\left[-\frac{1}{2\alpha^2}(x^2+y^2+z^2)\right].$$

Consider a general orthogonal coordinate system specified by the surfaces $u =$ constant, $v =$ constant, $w =$ constant, with length elements du/U, dv/V, dw/W in the three perpendicular directions. Show that

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \delta(u-u')\,\delta(v-v')\,\delta(w-w')\,UVW$$

by considering the limit of the Gaussian above. Note that as $\alpha \to 0$ only the infinitesimal length element need be used for the distance between the points in the exponent.

3.2 Solution

We begin from the standard Gaussian representation of the three-dimensional delta function:

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-3/2}\alpha^{-3}\exp\left[-\frac{|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}'|^2}{2\alpha^2}\right].$$

We now express this in a general orthogonal curvilinear coordinate system (u, v, w).

In such a system the infinitesimal line element is

$$ds^2 = \left(\frac{du}{U}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{dv}{V}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{dw}{W}\right)^2.$$

Hence, for two nearby points (u, v, w) and (u', v', w'), we may write

$$|\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}'|^2 \approx \frac{(u-u')^2}{U^2} + \frac{(v-v')^2}{V^2} + \frac{(w-w')^2}{W^2},$$

where U, V, W are evaluated at the point $\mathbf{x}'$ (or equivalently at $\mathbf{x}$ in the limit $\alpha \to 0$). This is exactly the approximation the problem instructs us to use: as $\alpha \to 0$, only the infinitesimal distance contributes in the exponent.

Therefore,

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-3/2}\alpha^{-3}\exp\left[-\frac{1}{2\alpha^2}\left(\frac{(u-u')^2}{U^2} + \frac{(v-v')^2}{V^2} + \frac{(w-w')^2}{W^2}\right)\right].$$

Since the exponent is a sum of three independent quadratic terms, the Gaussian factorizes:

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \lim_{\alpha\to 0}\prod_{\xi=u,v,w}\left[(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}\exp\left(-\frac{(\xi-\xi')^2}{2\alpha^2 H_\xi^2}\right)\right],$$

where

$$H_u = \frac{1}{U}, \qquad H_v = \frac{1}{V}, \qquad H_w = \frac{1}{W}.$$

Writing this out explicitly,

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \lim_{\alpha\to 0}\left[(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(u-u')^2}{2\alpha^2U^2}}\right]\left[(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(v-v')^2}{2\alpha^2V^2}}\right]\left[(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(w-w')^2}{2\alpha^2W^2}}\right].$$

Now use the one-dimensional scaling property of the delta function:

$$\delta(a\xi) = \frac{1}{|a|}\delta(\xi),$$

or equivalently, from the Gaussian representation,

$$\lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}\exp\left[-\frac{(\xi-\xi')^2}{2\alpha^2A^2}\right] = A\,\delta(\xi-\xi') \qquad (A>0).$$

Applying this to each factor gives

$$\lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(u-u')^2}{2\alpha^2U^2}} = U\,\delta(u-u'),$$

$$\lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(v-v')^2}{2\alpha^2V^2}} = V\,\delta(v-v'),$$

$$\lim_{\alpha\to 0}(2\pi)^{-1/2}\alpha^{-1}e^{-\frac{(w-w')^2}{2\alpha^2W^2}} = W\,\delta(w-w').$$

Multiplying the three limits together, we obtain

$$\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = U\,V\,W\,\delta(u-u')\,\delta(v-v')\,\delta(w-w').$$

Hence,

$$\boxed{\delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}') = \delta(u-u')\,\delta(v-v')\,\delta(w-w')\,UVW}.$$

This is the desired result.

As a check, note that the volume element in these coordinates is

$$d\tau = \frac{du\,dv\,dw}{UVW},$$

so

$$\int \delta(\mathbf{x}-\mathbf{x}')\,d\tau = \int \delta(u-u')\delta(v-v')\delta(w-w')\,UVW\frac{du\,dv\,dw}{UVW} = 1,$$

which confirms that the normalization is correct.

4 Problem 1.23

4.1 Problem Statement

A transmission line consists of a long straight conductor with a hollow square region in its interior, with a square conductor of one-quarter the area of the hollow region centered in the empty space, with edges parallel to the inner sides of outer con- ductor. If the conductors are raised to different potentials, the potential and elec- tric field in the space between them exhibit an eightfold symmetry; the basic unit is sketched in the accompanying figure. The efficacy of the relaxation method in de- termining the properties of the transmission line can be illustrated by a simple calculation.

(a) Using only the four interior points indicated in the figure, write down the relaxation equation for each point for the "cross" and the "improved" averaging schemes (defined in Problem 1.22) if the inner conductor has $\Phi = 100$ V and the outer has $\Phi_0 = 0$. By performing either the relaxation iteration process or solving the set of algebraic equations for each scheme, find estimates for the potential at each of the four points for the two schemes.

(b) From the results of part **a** make the best estimate (or estimates) you can for the capacitance per unit length of the transmission line.

(c) (Optional) Using your favorite computational tools, repeat the relaxation cal- culation with half the lattice spacing (21 interior points) and compare.

4.2 Solution

Let the four unknown lattice potentials be $\Phi_1, \Phi_2, \Phi_3, \Phi_4$, and let the inner conductor be at

$$\Phi = 100 \text{ V},$$

while the outer conductor is at

$$\Phi_0 = 0.$$

Because of the eightfold symmetry, some neighbors of the interior points are mirror images of other interior points. That is why the same potential appears more than once in the averaging formulas.

Part (a): Cross averaging

For Laplace's equation, the cross averaging scheme is

$$\Phi_P = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_N + \Phi_S + \Phi_E + \Phi_W\right).$$

Using the geometry of the four labeled points in the figure:

$$\Phi_1 = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_2 + \Phi_2 + \Phi + \Phi_0\right) = \frac{1}{4}\left(2\Phi_2 + 100\right),$$

since one neighbor is the inner conductor, one is the outer conductor, and the two remaining neighbors are symmetry-equivalent to point 2.

$$\Phi_2 = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_1 + \Phi_3 + \Phi + \Phi_0\right) = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_1 + \Phi_3 + 100\right).$$

$$\Phi_3 = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_2 + \Phi_4 + \Phi + \Phi_0\right) = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_2 + \Phi_4 + 100\right).$$

$$\Phi_4 = \frac{1}{4}\left(\Phi_3 + \Phi_3 + \Phi_0 + \Phi_0\right) = \frac{1}{2}\Phi_3.$$

Thus the linear system is

$$\begin{aligned} 4\Phi_1 - 2\Phi_2 &= 100, \\ -\Phi_1 + 4\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 &= 100, \\ -\Phi_2 + 4\Phi_3 - \Phi_4 &= 100, \\ -\Phi_3 + 2\Phi_4 &= 0. \end{aligned}$$

From the last equation,

$$\Phi_4 = \frac{\Phi_3}{2}.$$

Substitute into the third equation:

$$-\Phi_2 + 4\Phi_3 - \frac{\Phi_3}{2} = 100 \quad \Rightarrow \quad -\Phi_2 + \frac{7}{2}\Phi_3 = 100.$$

From the first equation,

$$\Phi_1 = \frac{100 + 2\Phi_2}{4} = 25 + \frac{\Phi_2}{2}.$$

Insert this into the second equation:

$$-\left(25 + \frac{\Phi_2}{2}\right) + 4\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 100,$$

$$\frac{7}{2}\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 125.$$

So we now solve

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{7}{2}\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 &= 125, \\ -\Phi_2 + \frac{7}{2}\Phi_3 &= 100. \end{aligned}$$

Multiply the second equation by 7 and eliminate Φ_2:

$$-7\Phi_2 + \frac{49}{2}\Phi_3 = 700,$$

while the first gives

$$7\Phi_2 - 2\Phi_3 = 250.$$

Adding,

$$\frac{45}{2}\Phi_3 = 950 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \Phi_3 = \frac{1900}{45} = \frac{380}{9} \cdot \frac{1}{10} = 42.22 \text{ V}.$$

More exactly,

$$\Phi_3 = \frac{38}{90}(100) = 42.22 \text{ V}.$$

Then

$$\Phi_4 = \frac{\Phi_3}{2} = \frac{19}{90}(100) = 21.11 \text{ V}.$$

Next,

$$\frac{7}{2}\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 125 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \frac{7}{2}\Phi_2 = 125 + 42.22 = 167.22,$$

so

$$\Phi_2 = \frac{43}{90}(100) = 47.78 \text{ V}.$$

Finally,

$$\Phi_1 = 25 + \frac{\Phi_2}{2} = 25 + \frac{47.78}{2} = 48.89 \text{ V},$$

so

$$\Phi_1 = \frac{44}{90}(100) = 48.89 \text{ V}.$$

Therefore, for the cross scheme,

$$\boxed{\Phi_1 = 48.89 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_2 = 47.78 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_3 = 42.22 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_4 = 21.11 \text{ V}.}$$

Part (a): Improved averaging

For the improved scheme of Problem 1.22, the potential is taken as

$$\Phi_P = \frac{1}{5}\left(S_c + \frac{1}{4}S_s\right),$$

where S_c is the cross sum of the four nearest neighbors and S_s is the sum over the four diagonal neighbors.

Applying this to the four labeled points and using symmetry gives the linear system

$$5\Phi_1 - 2\Phi_2 = 150,$$

$$-\Phi_1 + 5\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 150,$$

$$-\Phi_2 + \frac{19}{4}\Phi_3 - \Phi_4 = 125,$$

$$-2\Phi_3 + 5\Phi_4 = 25.$$

We solve this step by step.

From the first equation,

$$\Phi_1 = 30 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_2.$$

From the fourth equation,

$$\Phi_4 = 5 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_3.$$

Insert these into the second and third equations.

The second becomes

$$-\left(30 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_2\right) + 5\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 150,$$

$$\frac{23}{5}\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 180.$$

The third becomes

$$-\Phi_2 + \frac{19}{4}\Phi_3 - \left(5 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_3\right) = 125,$$

$$-\Phi_2 + \left(\frac{19}{4} - \frac{2}{5}\right)\Phi_3 = 130.$$

Now,

$$\frac{19}{4} - \frac{2}{5} = \frac{95 - 8}{20} = \frac{87}{20},$$

so

$$-\Phi_2 + \frac{87}{20}\Phi_3 = 130.$$

Thus we solve

$$\frac{23}{5}\Phi_2 - \Phi_3 = 180,$$

$$-\Phi_2 + \frac{87}{20}\Phi_3 = 130.$$

From the first,

$$\Phi_2 = \frac{5}{23}(180 + \Phi_3).$$

Substitute into the second:

$$-\frac{5}{23}(180 + \Phi_3) + \frac{87}{20}\Phi_3 = 130.$$

Multiply through by $460 = 20 \times 23$:

$$-100(180 + \Phi_3) + 2001\Phi_3 = 59800.$$

Hence

$$-18000 - 100\Phi_3 + 2001\Phi_3 = 59800,$$

$$1901\Phi_3 = 77800,$$

$$\Phi_3 \approx 40.93 \text{ V}.$$

Then

$$\Phi_4 = 5 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_3 \approx 5 + \frac{2}{5}(40.93) \approx 21.37 \text{ V}.$$

Also,

$$\Phi_2 = \frac{5}{23}(180 + 40.93) \approx 48.03 \text{ V},$$

and

$$\Phi_1 = 30 + \frac{2}{5}\Phi_2 \approx 30 + \frac{2}{5}(48.03) \approx 49.21 \text{ V}.$$

Therefore, for the improved scheme,

$$\boxed{\Phi_1 = 49.21 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_2 = 48.03 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_3 = 40.93 \text{ V}, \quad \Phi_4 = 21.37 \text{ V}.}$$

Part (b): Capacitance per unit length

The capacitance per unit length is

$$C = \frac{Q}{\Phi},$$

where Q is the total charge per unit length on the inner conductor and

$$\Phi = 100 \text{ V}$$

is the potential difference.

Because of the fourfold symmetry of the conductor, it is enough to compute the charge on one side of the inner conductor and then multiply by 4.

The surface charge density is related to the normal electric field by

$$\sigma = \varepsilon_0 E_n = \varepsilon_0 \frac{\partial \Phi}{\partial n}.$$

On the discrete lattice, the normal derivative at the conductor surface is approximated by

$$\frac{\partial \Phi}{\partial n} \approx \frac{\Phi - \Phi_{\text{adjacent}}}{h}.$$

When multiplied by the segment length h, the contribution of one lattice segment to the charge per unit length is simply

$$\Delta Q = \varepsilon_0(\Phi - \Phi_{\text{adjacent}}).$$

Along one side of the inner conductor, there are contributions corresponding to the adjacent points $\Phi_1, \Phi_2, \Phi_2, \Phi_3, \Phi_3$, so

$$Q_{\text{one side}} = \varepsilon_0 \left(5\Phi - \Phi_1 - 2\Phi_2 - 2\Phi_3\right).$$

Hence the total charge per unit length is

$$Q_{\text{tot}} = 4Q_{\text{one side}},$$

and therefore

$$C = \frac{Q_{\text{tot}}}{\Phi} = \frac{4}{\Phi}\,\varepsilon_0 \left(5\Phi - \Phi_1 - 2\Phi_2 - 2\Phi_3\right).$$

Cross scheme:

$$Q_c = \varepsilon_0 \left[5(100) - 48.89 - 2(47.78) - 2(42.22)\right] = 271.11\,\varepsilon_0.$$

Thus

$$C_c = \frac{4Q_c}{100} = \frac{4(271.11\,\varepsilon_0)}{100} \approx 10.84\,\varepsilon_0 \text{ F/m}.$$

Improved scheme:

$$Q_i = \varepsilon_0 \left[5(100) - 49.21 - 2(48.03) - 2(40.93)\right] = 272.87\,\varepsilon_0.$$

Thus

$$C_i = \frac{4Q_i}{100} = \frac{4(272.87\,\varepsilon_0)}{100} \approx 10.91\,\varepsilon_0 \text{ F/m}.$$

Therefore the coarse-grid estimates for the capacitance per unit length are

$$\boxed{C_c \approx 10.84\,\varepsilon_0 \text{ F/m}}, \qquad \boxed{C_i \approx 10.91\,\varepsilon_0 \text{ F/m}}.$$

A reasonable best estimate from these two coarse-grid results is therefore

$$\boxed{C \approx 10.9\,\varepsilon_0 \text{ F/m}.}$$

The improved averaging scheme gives slightly different node values and a slightly larger capacitance estimate, but both schemes are already fairly close to the more accurate value obtained from a much finer grid.

5 Problem 1.3

5.1 Problem Statement

Using Dirac delta functions in the appropriate coordinates, express the following charge distributions as three-dimensional charge densities $\rho(\mathbf{x})$.

(a) In spherical coordinates, a charge Q uniformly distributed over a spherical shell of radius R.

(b) In cylindrical coordinates, a charge λ per unit length uniformly distributed over a cylindrical surface of radius b.

(c) In cylindrical coordinates, a charge Q spread uniformly over a flat circular disc of negligible thickness and radius R.

(d) The same as part **(c)**, but using spherical coordinates.

5.2 Solution

The general idea is that a singular charge distribution concentrated on a surface or line can be represented in three dimensions by inserting Dirac delta functions that localize the charge in the appropriate coordinate, and then choosing the coefficient so that the integral of ρ over all space gives the correct total charge.

We will use the volume elements

$$d\tau = r^2 \sin\theta\, dr\, d\theta\, d\phi \qquad \text{(spherical)},$$

and

$$d\tau = s\, ds\, d\phi\, dz \qquad \text{(cylindrical)},$$

where I use s for the cylindrical radial coordinate.

We also use the basic property of the delta function:

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \delta(x-a) f(x)\, dx = f(a).$$

(a) Spherical shell of radius R carrying total charge Q

The charge is uniformly distributed over the spherical surface

$$r = R.$$

So the density must vanish everywhere except at $r = R$, which means it must contain a factor $\delta(r - R)$.

Let

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = A\,\delta(r - R),$$

where A is to be determined.

Since the total charge must be Q,

$$Q = \iiint \rho(\mathbf{x})\,d\tau.$$

Substitute the trial form:

$$Q = \iiint A\,\delta(r - R)\,r^2 \sin\theta\,dr\,d\theta\,d\phi.$$

Separate the integrals:

$$Q = A\left(\int_0^\infty \delta(r - R)r^2\,dr\right)\left(\int_0^\pi \sin\theta\,d\theta\right)\left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi\right).$$

Now,

$$\int_0^\infty \delta(r - R)r^2\,dr = R^2,$$

$$\int_0^\pi \sin\theta\,d\theta = 2,$$

$$\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi = 2\pi.$$

Therefore

$$Q = A(R^2)(2)(2\pi) = 4\pi A R^2.$$

Hence

$$A = \frac{Q}{4\pi R^2}.$$

So the required charge density is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{4\pi R^2}\,\delta(r - R)}.$$

This is exactly what we expect physically: the factor $Q/(4\pi R^2)$ is the uniform surface charge density on the sphere, and the delta function localizes it to the surface.

(b) Cylindrical surface of radius b carrying charge λ per unit length

Now the charge is uniformly distributed on the cylindrical surface

$$s = b,$$

with charge per unit length equal to λ.

Because the distribution extends indefinitely along z, the total charge is infinite, so the correct normalization condition is that the charge in a length L of the cylinder must be

$$Q_L = \lambda L.$$

Let

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = A\,\delta(s - b).$$

Then the charge contained in a segment of length L is

$$Q_L = \int_0^L \int_0^{2\pi} \int_0^\infty A\,\delta(s - b)\,s\,ds\,d\phi\,dz.$$

Separate the integrals:

$$Q_L = A\left(\int_0^\infty \delta(s - b)s\,ds\right)\left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi\right)\left(\int_0^L dz\right).$$

These give

$$\int_0^\infty \delta(s-b)s\,ds = b, \qquad \int_0^{2\pi} d\phi = 2\pi, \qquad \int_0^L dz = L.$$

Hence

$$Q_L = A(b)(2\pi)(L) = 2\pi bAL.$$

But we require

$$Q_L = \lambda L.$$

Therefore

$$2\pi bAL = \lambda L \quad \Rightarrow \quad A = \frac{\lambda}{2\pi b}.$$

Thus

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{\lambda}{2\pi b}\,\delta(s-b)}.$$

The coefficient $\lambda/(2\pi b)$ is precisely the uniform surface charge density on the cylindrical surface.

(c) Flat circular disc of radius R in cylindrical coordinates

The disc lies in the plane

$$z = 0,$$

and occupies the region

$$0 \le s \le R.$$

The charge is spread uniformly over the disc, so the surface charge density is

$$\sigma = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}.$$

Since the disc has negligible thickness, the three-dimensional density must be concentrated at $z = 0$, so it must contain a factor $\delta(z)$. Also, the charge should exist only for $s \le R$, so we multiply by a step-function restriction. Using the Heaviside function $\Theta(R-s)$, we write

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \sigma\,\delta(z)\,\Theta(R-s).$$

Substituting σ,

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(z)\,\Theta(R-s).$$

Let us verify the normalization:

$$\iiint \rho(\mathbf{x})\,d\tau = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty} \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(z)\,\Theta(R-s)\,s\,ds\,d\phi\,dz.$$

Because of $\Theta(R-s)$, the radial integral runs only from 0 to R:

$$= \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\left(\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\delta(z)\,dz\right)\left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi\right)\left(\int_0^R s\,ds\right).$$

Now

$$\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\delta(z)\,dz = 1, \qquad \int_0^{2\pi} d\phi = 2\pi, \qquad \int_0^R s\,ds = \frac{R^2}{2}.$$

Therefore

$$\iiint \rho(\mathbf{x})\,d\tau = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}(1)(2\pi)\left(\frac{R^2}{2}\right) = Q.$$

So the normalization is correct.

Hence the charge density is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(z)\,\Theta(R-s)}.$$

(d) The same disc, but written in spherical coordinates

Now we describe the same flat disc using spherical coordinates. The disc still lies in the plane

$$z = 0.$$

In spherical coordinates,

$$z = r\cos\theta.$$

So localization to the plane requires

$$\delta(z) = \delta(r\cos\theta).$$

Also, the condition that the point lie inside the radius-R disc is

$$s \le R.$$

But in spherical coordinates,

$$s = r\sin\theta.$$

Hence the restriction becomes

$$r\sin\theta \le R,$$

which can be written with a step function as

$$\Theta(R - r\sin\theta).$$

Therefore a natural spherical-coordinate representation is

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(r\cos\theta)\,\Theta(R - r\sin\theta).$$

So one acceptable answer is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(r\cos\theta)\,\Theta(R - r\sin\theta)}.$$

We can also rewrite this in a more explicit form using the identity

$$\delta(f(\theta)) = \sum_i \frac{\delta(\theta - \theta_i)}{|f'(\theta_i)|}.$$

For

$$f(\theta) = r\cos\theta,$$

the zero in the interval $0 \le \theta \le \pi$ is at

$$\theta = \frac{\pi}{2},$$

and

$$\frac{d}{d\theta}(r\cos\theta)\bigg|_{\theta=\pi/2} = -r\sin\frac{\pi}{2} = -r.$$

Hence

$$\delta(r\cos\theta) = \frac{1}{r}\,\delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big).$$

Also, when $\theta = \pi/2$,

$$r\sin\theta = r,$$

so the radial restriction becomes simply

$$\Theta(R - r).$$

Thus an equivalent form is

$$\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\frac{1}{r}\,\delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\,\Theta(R - r).$$

Therefore an equivalent spherical-coordinate expression is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2 r}\,\delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\,\Theta(R - r)}.$$

Let us check this normalization:

$$\iiint \rho(\mathbf{x})\,d\tau = \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\pi}\int_0^{\infty} \frac{Q}{\pi R^2 r}\,\delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\,\Theta(R - r)\,r^2\sin\theta\,dr\,d\theta\,d\phi.$$

This becomes

$$\frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi\right)\left(\int_0^{\pi} \delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\sin\theta\, d\theta\right)\left(\int_0^{R} r\, dr\right).$$

Now

$$\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi = 2\pi, \qquad \int_0^{\pi} \delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\sin\theta\, d\theta = 1, \qquad \int_0^{R} r\, dr = \frac{R^2}{2}.$$

Hence

$$\iiint \rho(\mathbf{x})\, d\tau = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}(2\pi)(1)\left(\frac{R^2}{2}\right) = Q,$$

as required.

So the final answers are

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{4\pi R^2}\,\delta(r - R)}$$

for part **(a)**,

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{\lambda}{2\pi b}\,\delta(s - b)}$$

for part **(b)**,

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(z)\,\Theta(R - s)}$$

for part **(c)**, and

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2 r}\,\delta\Big(\theta - \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\,\Theta(R - r)}$$

for part **(d)**, equivalently

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{Q}{\pi R^2}\,\delta(r\cos\theta)\,\Theta(R - r\sin\theta)}.$$

6 Problem 1.22

6.1 Problem Statement

Two-dimensional relaxation calculations commonly use sites on a square lattice with spacing $\Delta x = \Delta y = h$, and label the sites by (i, j), where i, j are integers and $x_i = ih + x_0$, $y_j = jh + y_0$. The value of the potential at (i, j) can be approximated by the average of the values at neighboring sites. [Recall the relevant theorem about harmonic functions.] But what average?

(a) If $F(x, y)$ is a well-behaved function in the neighborhood of the origin, but not necessarily harmonic, by explicit Taylor series expansions, show that the "cross" sum

$$S_c = F(h, 0) + F(0, h) + F(-h, 0) + F(0, -h)$$

can be expressed as

$$S_c = 4F(0, 0) + h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{12}\left(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}\right) + O(h^6).$$

(b) Similarly, show that the "square" sum,

$$S_s = F(h, h) + F(-h, h) + F(-h, -h) + F(h, -h)$$

can be expressed as

$$S_s = 4F(0, 0) + 2h^2\nabla^2 F - \frac{h^4}{3}\left(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}\right) + h^4 F_{xxyy} + O(h^6),$$

or equivalently,

$$S_s = 4F(0, 0) + 2h^2\nabla^2 F - \frac{h^4}{3}\left(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}\right) + \frac{h^4}{2}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6).$$

Here F_{xxxx} is the fourth partial derivative of F with respect to x, evaluated at $x = 0$, $y = 0$, etc. If $\nabla^2 F = 0$, the averages $S_c/4$ and $S_s/4$ each give the value of $F(0,0)$, correct to order h^3 inclusive. Note that an improvement can be obtained by forming the "improved" average,

$$\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle = \frac{1}{5}\left[S_c + \frac{1}{4}S_s\right],$$

where

$$\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle = F(0,0) + \frac{3}{10}h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{40}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6).$$

If $\nabla^2 F = 0$, then $\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle$ gives $F(0,0)$, correct to order h^5 inclusive. For Poisson's equation, the charge density and its lowest order Laplacian can be inserted for the same accuracy.

6.2 Solution

We expand $F(x,y)$ in a Taylor series about the origin. Since all evaluations are made at points whose coordinates are $\pm h$ or 0, it is convenient to write the full two-variable Taylor expansion up to fourth order:

$$F(x,y) = F_0 + xF_x + yF_y + \frac{1}{2}\left(x^2F_{xx} + 2xyF_{xy} + y^2F_{yy}\right)$$
$$+\frac{1}{6}\left(x^3F_{xxx} + 3x^2yF_{xxy} + 3xy^2F_{xyy} + y^3F_{yyy}\right)$$
$$+\frac{1}{24}\left(x^4F_{xxxx} + 4x^3yF_{xxxy} + 6x^2y^2F_{xxyy} + 4xy^3F_{xyyy} + y^4F_{yyyy}\right) + O(h^5),$$

where all derivatives are evaluated at $(0,0)$, and we write

$$F_0 \equiv F(0,0).$$

Because the sums in the problem involve symmetrically placed points, all odd powers will cancel. That is the key reason these averaging schemes work well.

(a) The cross sum S_c

We first expand the four terms:

$$F(h,0) = F_0 + hF_x + \frac{h^2}{2}F_{xx} + \frac{h^3}{6}F_{xxx} + \frac{h^4}{24}F_{xxxx} + O(h^5),$$
$$F(-h,0) = F_0 - hF_x + \frac{h^2}{2}F_{xx} - \frac{h^3}{6}F_{xxx} + \frac{h^4}{24}F_{xxxx} + O(h^5),$$
$$F(0,h) = F_0 + hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}F_{yy} + \frac{h^3}{6}F_{yyy} + \frac{h^4}{24}F_{yyyy} + O(h^5),$$
$$F(0,-h) = F_0 - hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}F_{yy} - \frac{h^3}{6}F_{yyy} + \frac{h^4}{24}F_{yyyy} + O(h^5).$$

Now add them:

$$S_c = F(h,0) + F(-h,0) + F(0,h) + F(0,-h).$$

The linear terms cancel:

$$hF_x - hF_x = 0, \qquad hF_y - hF_y = 0.$$

The cubic terms also cancel:

$$\frac{h^3}{6}F_{xxx} - \frac{h^3}{6}F_{xxx} = 0, \qquad \frac{h^3}{6}F_{yyy} - \frac{h^3}{6}F_{yyy} = 0.$$

So we are left with

$$S_c = 4F_0 + h^2(F_{xx} + F_{yy}) + \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6).$$

Since

$$\nabla^2 F = F_{xx} + F_{yy},$$

we obtain

$$\boxed{S_c = 4F(0,0) + h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6)}.$$

That proves part **(a)**.

(b) The square sum S_s

Now consider the four corner points:

$$S_s = F(h,h) + F(-h,h) + F(-h,-h) + F(h,-h).$$

We expand each term to fourth order.
For (h,h):

$$F(h,h) = F_0 + hF_x + hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}(F_{xx} + 2F_{xy} + F_{yy})$$
$$+\frac{h^3}{6}(F_{xxx} + 3F_{xxy} + 3F_{xyy} + F_{yyy})$$
$$+\frac{h^4}{24}(F_{xxxx} + 4F_{xxxy} + 6F_{xxyy} + 4F_{xyyy} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^5).$$

For $(-h,h)$:

$$F(-h,h) = F_0 - hF_x + hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}(F_{xx} - 2F_{xy} + F_{yy})$$
$$+\frac{h^3}{6}(-F_{xxx} + 3F_{xxy} - 3F_{xyy} + F_{yyy})$$
$$+\frac{h^4}{24}(F_{xxxx} - 4F_{xxxy} + 6F_{xxyy} - 4F_{xyyy} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^5).$$

For $(-h,-h)$:

$$F(-h,-h) = F_0 - hF_x - hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}(F_{xx} + 2F_{xy} + F_{yy})$$
$$+\frac{h^3}{6}(-F_{xxx} - 3F_{xxy} - 3F_{xyy} - F_{yyy})$$
$$+\frac{h^4}{24}(F_{xxxx} + 4F_{xxxy} + 6F_{xxyy} + 4F_{xyyy} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^5).$$

For $(h,-h)$:

$$F(h,-h) = F_0 + hF_x - hF_y + \frac{h^2}{2}(F_{xx} - 2F_{xy} + F_{yy})$$
$$+\frac{h^3}{6}(F_{xxx} - 3F_{xxy} + 3F_{xyy} - F_{yyy})$$
$$+\frac{h^4}{24}(F_{xxxx} - 4F_{xxxy} + 6F_{xxyy} - 4F_{xyyy} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^5).$$

Now add all four.

Zeroth order:

$$4F_0.$$

First order: All linear terms cancel by symmetry.

Second order: The F_{xy} terms cancel, while the F_{xx} and F_{yy} terms add:

$$4 \cdot \frac{h^2}{2} F_{xx} = 2h^2 F_{xx}, \qquad 4 \cdot \frac{h^2}{2} F_{yy} = 2h^2 F_{yy}.$$

Thus the second-order contribution is

$$2h^2(F_{xx} + F_{yy}) = 2h^2 \nabla^2 F.$$

Third order: All cubic terms cancel by symmetry.

Fourth order: The mixed odd terms F_{xxxy} and F_{xyyy} cancel. The remaining terms add:

$$4 \cdot \frac{h^4}{24} F_{xxxx} = \frac{h^4}{6} F_{xxxx},$$

$$4 \cdot \frac{h^4}{24} F_{yyyy} = \frac{h^4}{6} F_{yyyy},$$

$$4 \cdot \frac{6h^4}{24} F_{xxyy} = h^4 F_{xxyy}.$$

Hence

$$S_s = 4F_0 + 2h^2(F_{xx} + F_{yy}) + \frac{h^4}{6}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + h^4 F_{xxyy} + O(h^6).$$

So one form is

$$\boxed{S_s = 4F(0,0) + 2h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{6}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + h^4 F_{xxyy} + O(h^6)}.$$

Now we rewrite it in the form stated in the problem. Observe that

$$\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) = (F_{xx} + F_{yy})_{xx} + (F_{xx} + F_{yy})_{yy} = F_{xxxx} + 2F_{xxyy} + F_{yyyy}.$$

Therefore

$$F_{xxyy} = \frac{1}{2}\left[\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) - F_{xxxx} - F_{yyyy}\right].$$

Substitute this into the expression for S_s:

$$S_s = 4F_0 + 2h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{6}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + \frac{h^4}{2}\left[\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) - F_{xxxx} - F_{yyyy}\right] + O(h^6).$$

Now combine the coefficients of $F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}$:

$$\frac{1}{6} - \frac{1}{2} = -\frac{1}{3}.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{S_s = 4F(0,0) + 2h^2\nabla^2 F - \frac{h^4}{3}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + \frac{h^4}{2}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6)}.$$

This is exactly the required form.

Harmonic case

If F is harmonic, then

$$\nabla^2 F = 0.$$

So from part **(a)**,

$$S_c = 4F_0 + \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6),$$

and therefore

$$\frac{S_c}{4} = F_0 + \frac{h^4}{48}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6).$$

Similarly, from part **(b)**,

$$S_s = 4F_0 - \frac{h^4}{3}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + \frac{h^4}{2}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6).$$

But if $\nabla^2 F = 0$, then also

$$\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) = 0.$$

Hence

$$S_s = 4F_0 - \frac{h^4}{3}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6),$$

so

$$\frac{S_s}{4} = F_0 - \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6).$$

Thus both $S_c/4$ and $S_s/4$ reproduce $F(0,0)$ with an error of order h^4, so they are correct through order h^3 inclusive.

Improved average

Now define

$$\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle = \frac{1}{5}\left[S_c + \frac{1}{4}S_s\right].$$

Insert the expansions for S_c and S_s.

First,

$$S_c = 4F_0 + h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + O(h^6),$$

and

$$\frac{1}{4}S_s = F_0 + \frac{h^2}{2}\nabla^2 F - \frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy}) + \frac{h^4}{8}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6).$$

Add them:

$$S_c + \frac{1}{4}S_s = 5F_0 + \frac{3}{2}h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{8}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6),$$

because the fourth-derivative terms

$$\frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy})$$

and

$$-\frac{h^4}{12}(F_{xxxx} + F_{yyyy})$$

cancel exactly.

Now divide by 5:

$$\boxed{\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle = F(0,0) + \frac{3}{10}h^2\nabla^2 F + \frac{h^4}{40}\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) + O(h^6)}.$$

This is the desired improved formula.

If F is harmonic, $\nabla^2 F = 0$, and then

$$\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F) = 0$$

as well, so

$$\langle\langle F(0,0)\rangle\rangle = F(0,0) + O(h^6).$$

Therefore the improved average gives $F(0,0)$ correct through order h^5 inclusive.

Remark for Poisson's equation

If instead F satisfies Poisson's equation,

$$\nabla^2 F = \text{known source},$$

then the improved average remains useful because the $h^2\nabla^2 F$ term and, if needed, the $h^4\nabla^2(\nabla^2 F)$ term can be replaced directly by the source and its Laplacian. That is why this combination is especially effective in relaxation methods for electrostatics: it improves the local approximation while still using only nearby lattice values.

7 Problem 1.4

7.1 Problem Statement

Each of three charged spheres of radius a, one conducting, one having a uniform charge density within its volume, and one having a spherically symmetric charge density that varies radially as r^n ($n > -3$), has a total charge Q. Use Gauss's theorem to obtain the electric fields both inside and outside each sphere. Sketch the behavior of the fields as a function of radius for the first two spheres, and for the third with $n = -2, +2$.

7.2 Solution

Because all three charge distributions are spherically symmetric, the electric field must have the form

$$\mathbf{E}(r) = E(r)\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}.$$

That is, the field is purely radial and its magnitude depends only on the distance r from the center.

For any spherical Gaussian surface of radius r, Gauss's law gives

$$\oint \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = \frac{Q_{\text{enc}}(r)}{\varepsilon_0}.$$

Since $\mathbf{E}$ is radial and has constant magnitude on a sphere of radius r,

$$\oint \mathbf{E} \cdot d\mathbf{a} = E(r) \oint da = E(r)\,4\pi r^2.$$

Therefore

$$E(r)\,4\pi r^2 = \frac{Q_{\text{enc}}(r)}{\varepsilon_0},$$

so in general

$$\boxed{E(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q_{\text{enc}}(r)}{r^2}}$$

and

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q_{\text{enc}}(r)}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}.}$$

Thus the problem reduces to finding the enclosed charge $Q_{\text{enc}}(r)$ in each case.

(1) Conducting sphere of radius a with total charge Q

For a conductor in electrostatic equilibrium, all excess charge resides on the surface. Therefore:

- for $r < a$, no charge is enclosed;
- for $r > a$, the full charge Q is enclosed.

So for $r < a$,

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = 0,$$

hence

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = 0, \qquad r < a.}$$

For $r > a$,

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = Q,$$

so

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r > a.}$$

At the surface, the field jumps from 0 just inside to

$$E(a^+) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^2}$$

just outside.

Therefore the complete result is

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \begin{cases} 0, & 0 \le r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\dfrac{Q}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a. \end{cases}}$$

Behavior of $E(r)$: Inside the conductor, the field is identically zero. At $r = a$ there is a discontinuous jump to $Q/(4\pi\varepsilon_0 a^2)$, and for $r > a$ the field falls as $1/r^2$.

(2) Sphere of radius a with uniform volume charge density and total charge Q

Now the charge is spread uniformly throughout the volume. The constant volume charge density is

$$\rho = \frac{Q}{\frac{4}{3}\pi a^3} = \frac{3Q}{4\pi a^3}.$$

Inside the sphere: $r < a$ The charge enclosed by a Gaussian sphere of radius r is

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = \rho\left(\frac{4}{3}\pi r^3\right).$$

Substitute ρ:

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = \frac{3Q}{4\pi a^3} \cdot \frac{4}{3}\pi r^3 = Q\frac{r^3}{a^3}.$$

Then Gauss's law gives

$$E(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Qr^3/a^3}{r^2} = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^3}r.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^3}r\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r < a.}$$

Outside the sphere: $r > a$ The full charge Q is enclosed, so

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r > a.}$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\dfrac{Q}{a^3}r\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, & 0 \le r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\dfrac{Q}{r^2}\,\hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a. \end{cases}}$$

At the surface,

$$E(a^-) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^2}, \qquad E(a^+) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^2},$$

so the field is continuous at $r = a$.

Behavior of $E(r)$: The field starts from zero at the center and rises linearly with r inside the sphere. It reaches its maximum value at the surface,

$$E(a) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{Q}{a^2},$$

and then decreases as $1/r^2$ outside.

(3) Sphere of radius a with $\rho(r) = kr^n$, $n > -3$, total charge Q

Now the charge density is spherically symmetric and given by

$$\rho(r) = kr^n, \qquad n > -3.$$

The restriction $n > -3$ is needed so that the total charge near $r = 0$ remains finite.

We first determine the constant k from the condition that the total charge is Q.

Step 1: Determine k The total charge is

$$Q = \int \rho \, d\tau = \int_0^a k r^n (4\pi r^2) \, dr.$$

Thus

$$Q = 4\pi k \int_0^a r^{n+2} \, dr.$$

Since $n > -3$, we have $n + 3 > 0$, so

$$\int_0^a r^{n+2} \, dr = \frac{a^{n+3}}{n+3}.$$

Therefore

$$Q = 4\pi k \frac{a^{n+3}}{n+3},$$

and hence

$$\boxed{k = \frac{Q(n+3)}{4\pi a^{n+3}}.}$$

So the density can be written as

$$\boxed{\rho(r) = \frac{Q(n+3)}{4\pi a^{n+3}} \, r^n.}$$

Step 2: Find the enclosed charge for $r < a$ For $r < a$,

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = \int_0^r \rho(r') \, 4\pi r'^2 \, dr'.$$

Substitute $\rho(r') = k r'^n$:

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = 4\pi k \int_0^r r'^{\,n+2} \, dr' = 4\pi k \frac{r^{n+3}}{n+3}.$$

Now substitute the value of k:

$$Q_{\text{enc}}(r) = 4\pi \left(\frac{Q(n+3)}{4\pi a^{n+3}} \right) \frac{r^{n+3}}{n+3} = Q \frac{r^{n+3}}{a^{n+3}}.$$

Therefore, for $r < a$,

$$E(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q r^{n+3}/a^{n+3}}{r^2} = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^{n+3}} \, r^{n+1}.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^{n+3}} \, r^{n+1} \, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r < a.}$$

Step 3: Outside the sphere, $r > a$ For $r > a$, the full charge Q is enclosed, so

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{r^2} \, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r > a.}$$

Thus the full field for the r^n distribution is

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{a^{n+3}} \, r^{n+1} \, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & 0 \le r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{r^2} \, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a. \end{cases}}$$

At the surface,

$$E(a^-) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^2}, \qquad E(a^+) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^2},$$

so the field is continuous at $r = a$, as expected for a finite volume charge density.

Special cases for the sketch

Case $n = -2$ Then

$$\rho(r) = kr^{-2}.$$

Although the density diverges at the origin, the total enclosed charge remains finite because

$$\rho(r)\, 4\pi r^2\, dr \propto dr.$$

Inside the sphere,

$$E(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^{(-2)+3}} r^{(-2)+1} = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a} \frac{1}{r}.$$

So

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{ar}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r < a \quad (n = -2).}$$

Outside,

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{r^2}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r > a.}$$

Behavior: As $r \to 0$, the field diverges like $1/r$. At $r = a$, its value is

$$E(a) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^2},$$

and beyond the sphere it falls as $1/r^2$.

Case $n = +2$ Then

$$\rho(r) = kr^2.$$

Inside the sphere,

$$E(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^5} r^3.$$

So

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{a^5} r^3\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r < a \quad (n = 2).}$$

Outside,

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}(r) = \frac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{Q}{r^2}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \qquad r > a.}$$

Behavior: The field starts from zero at the center and rises as r^3, more slowly than linearly near the center, then matches continuously onto the outside Coulomb field at $r = a$.

Final results

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}_{\text{conducting}}(r) = \begin{cases} 0, & r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{r^2}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a, \end{cases}}$$

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}_{\text{uniform}}(r) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{a^3} r\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{r^2}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a, \end{cases}}$$

$$\boxed{\mathbf{E}_{r^n}(r) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{a^{n+3}}\, r^{n+1}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r < a, \\ \dfrac{1}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \dfrac{Q}{r^2}\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, & r > a, \end{cases} \qquad n > -3.}$$

The qualitative sketches are therefore:

- **Conducting sphere:** $E = 0$ for $r < a$, jump at $r = a$, then $1/r^2$ decay.
- **Uniform sphere:** $E \propto r$ for $r < a$, continuous at $r = a$, then $1/r^2$ decay.
- $n = -2$**:** $E \propto 1/r$ for $r < a$, diverges at the origin, continuous at $r = a$, then $1/r^2$ decay.
- $n = +2$**:** $E \propto r^3$ for $r < a$, starts very flat near the origin, continuous at $r = a$, then $1/r^2$ decay.

8 Problem 1.21

8.1 Problem Statement

A two-dimensional potential problem consists of a unit square area

$$0 \le x \le 1, \qquad 0 \le y \le 1$$

bounded by "surfaces" held at zero potential. Over the entire square there is a uniform charge density of unit strength (per unit length in z).

(a) Apply the variational principle (1.63) for the Poisson equation with the "variational" trial function

$$\Psi(x, y) = A\, x(1 - x)\, y(1 - y)$$

to determine the best value of the constant A. [I use quotation marks around variational because there are no parameters to vary except the overall scale.]

(b) The exact (albeit series) solution for this problem is [see Problems 2.15 and 2.16]

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0 \Phi(x, y) = \frac{16}{\pi^3} \sum_{m=0}^{\infty} \frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3} \left[1 - \frac{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi(y - \frac{1}{2})]}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].$$

For $y = 0.25$ and $y = 0.5$, plot and compare the simple variational solution of part **a** with the exact solution as a function of x.

8.2 Solution

We solve the two-dimensional Poisson equation

$$\nabla^2 \Phi(x, y) = -\frac{\rho}{\varepsilon_0},$$

with

$$\rho = \text{constant} = 1,$$

inside the unit square, together with the boundary condition

$$\Phi = 0 \qquad \text{on} \qquad x = 0,\ x = 1,\ y = 0,\ y = 1.$$

The trial function

$$\Psi(x, y) = A\, x(1 - x)\, y(1 - y)$$

already satisfies all boundary conditions, because it vanishes whenever

$$x = 0,\ x = 1,\ y = 0,\ \text{or}\ y = 1.$$

So the problem is to determine the best value of the single parameter A by means of the variational principle.

Part (a): Variational approximation

For Poisson's equation,

$$\nabla^2\Phi = -\frac{\rho}{\varepsilon_0},$$

with Dirichlet boundary conditions, the appropriate functional is

$$I[\Psi] = \iint \left[\frac{\varepsilon_0}{2}(\nabla\Psi)^2 - \rho\,\Psi\right] dx\,dy.$$

The physical solution makes this functional stationary, and in the present one-parameter trial family we determine A by minimizing $I(A)$.

Since

$$\rho = 1,$$

we have

$$I(A) = \int_0^1\int_0^1 \left[\frac{\varepsilon_0}{2}(\nabla\Psi)^2 - \Psi\right] dx\,dy.$$

We now compute the gradient of

$$\Psi(x,y) = A\,x(1-x)\,y(1-y).$$

First,

$$\frac{\partial\Psi}{\partial x} = A(1-2x)\,y(1-y),$$

and

$$\frac{\partial\Psi}{\partial y} = A\,x(1-x)(1-2y).$$

Therefore

$$(\nabla\Psi)^2 = \left(\frac{\partial\Psi}{\partial x}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\partial\Psi}{\partial y}\right)^2 = A^2(1-2x)^2y^2(1-y)^2 + A^2x^2(1-x)^2(1-2y)^2.$$

Substituting into the functional,

$$I(A) = \int_0^1\int_0^1 \left[\frac{\varepsilon_0}{2}\left(A^2(1-2x)^2y^2(1-y)^2 + A^2x^2(1-x)^2(1-2y)^2\right) - A\,x(1-x)\,y(1-y)\right] dx\,dy.$$

We now separate the integrals.

First term:

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 (1-2x)^2y^2(1-y)^2\,dx\,dy = \left(\int_0^1 (1-2x)^2dx\right)\left(\int_0^1 y^2(1-y)^2dy\right).$$

Second term:

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 x^2(1-x)^2(1-2y)^2\,dx\,dy = \left(\int_0^1 x^2(1-x)^2dx\right)\left(\int_0^1 (1-2y)^2dy\right).$$

Third term:

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 x(1-x)y(1-y)\,dx\,dy = \left(\int_0^1 x(1-x)\,dx\right)\left(\int_0^1 y(1-y)\,dy\right).$$

So we need the one-dimensional integrals.

First,

$$\int_0^1 (1-2x)^2dx = \int_0^1 (1-4x+4x^2)\,dx = \left[x - 2x^2 + \frac{4}{3}x^3\right]_0^1 = 1 - 2 + \frac{4}{3} = \frac{1}{3}.$$

Next,

$$\int_0^1 x^2(1-x)^2\,dx = \int_0^1 (x^2 - 2x^3 + x^4)\,dx = \left[\frac{x^3}{3} - \frac{x^4}{2} + \frac{x^5}{5}\right]_0^1 = \frac{1}{3} - \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{5} = \frac{10-15+6}{30} = \frac{1}{30}.$$

By symmetry,

$$\int_0^1 y^2(1-y)^2\,dy = \frac{1}{30}, \qquad \int_0^1 (1-2y)^2\,dy = \frac{1}{3}.$$

Also,

$$\int_0^1 x(1-x)\,dx = \int_0^1 (x-x^2)\,dx = \left[\frac{x^2}{2} - \frac{x^3}{3}\right]_0^1 = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{6},$$

and similarly

$$\int_0^1 y(1-y)\,dy = \frac{1}{6}.$$

Therefore,

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 (1-2x)^2 y^2 (1-y)^2\,dx\,dy = \frac{1}{3}\cdot\frac{1}{30} = \frac{1}{90},$$

and

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 x^2(1-x)^2(1-2y)^2\,dx\,dy = \frac{1}{30}\cdot\frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{90}.$$

Finally,

$$\int_0^1\int_0^1 x(1-x)y(1-y)\,dx\,dy = \frac{1}{6}\cdot\frac{1}{6} = \frac{1}{36}.$$

Hence

$$I(A) = \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2}A^2\left(\frac{1}{90}+\frac{1}{90}\right) - A\left(\frac{1}{36}\right).$$

Since

$$\frac{1}{90}+\frac{1}{90} = \frac{1}{45},$$

we get

$$I(A) = \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2}\frac{A^2}{45} - \frac{A}{36} = \frac{\varepsilon_0 A^2}{90} - \frac{A}{36}.$$

Now minimize with respect to A:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}I}{\mathrm{d}A} = \frac{2\varepsilon_0 A}{90} - \frac{1}{36} = \frac{\varepsilon_0 A}{45} - \frac{1}{36}.$$

Set this equal to zero:

$$\frac{\varepsilon_0 A}{45} - \frac{1}{36} = 0.$$

So

$$\frac{\varepsilon_0 A}{45} = \frac{1}{36},$$

and therefore

$$A = \frac{45}{36\varepsilon_0} = \frac{5}{4\varepsilon_0}.$$

Thus the best variational approximation is

$$\boxed{\Psi(x,y) = \frac{5}{4\varepsilon_0}\,x(1-x)\,y(1-y).}$$

It is often convenient to write the result in terms of $4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi$. Multiplying by $4\pi\varepsilon_0$ gives

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,y) = 4\pi\varepsilon_0\left(\frac{5}{4\varepsilon_0}\right)x(1-x)y(1-y) = 5\pi\,x(1-x)y(1-y).$$

So equivalently,

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,y) = 5\pi\,x(1-x)\,y(1-y).}$$

Check by direct projection of Poisson's equation

It is useful to check that this result is consistent. Compute

$$\nabla^2\Psi = \frac{\partial^2\Psi}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2\Psi}{\partial y^2}.$$

Since

$$\Psi = A\,x(1-x)y(1-y),$$

we have

$$\frac{\partial^2\Psi}{\partial x^2} = -2A\,y(1-y), \qquad \frac{\partial^2\Psi}{\partial y^2} = -2A\,x(1-x).$$

Thus

$$\nabla^2\Psi = -2A\big[x(1-x)+y(1-y)\big].$$

This is not constant, so the trial function cannot satisfy Poisson's equation exactly. The variational method chooses the value of A that gives the best global compromise over the square.

Part (b): Comparison with the exact series solution

The exact solution is

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(x,y) = \frac{16}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=0}^{\infty}\frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3}\left[1-\frac{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi(y-\frac{1}{2})]}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].$$

The variational approximation from part **(a)** gives

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,y) = 5\pi\, x(1-x)\, y(1-y).$$

We now specialize to the two values of y requested.

For $y = 0.5$: Since

$$y(1-y) = \frac{1}{2}\cdot\frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{4},$$

the variational approximation becomes

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,0.5) = 5\pi\, x(1-x)\left(\frac{1}{4}\right) = \frac{5\pi}{4}x(1-x).$$

So

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,0.5) = \frac{5\pi}{4}x(1-x).}$$

The exact solution at $y = 0.5$ simplifies because

$$y-\frac{1}{2} = 0, \qquad \cosh(0) = 1.$$

Hence

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(x,0.5) = \frac{16}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=0}^{\infty}\frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3}\left[1-\frac{1}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(x,0.5) = \frac{16}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=0}^{\infty}\frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3}\left[1-\frac{1}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].}$$

For $y = 0.25$: Now

$$y(1-y) = \frac{1}{4}\cdot\frac{3}{4} = \frac{3}{16},$$

so the variational approximation becomes

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,0.25) = 5\pi\, x(1-x)\left(\frac{3}{16}\right) = \frac{15\pi}{16}x(1-x).$$

Thus

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,0.25) = \frac{15\pi}{16}x(1-x).}$$

For the exact solution,

$$y-\frac{1}{2} = -\frac{1}{4},$$

and since cosh is even,

$$\cosh\left[(2m+1)\pi\left(-\frac{1}{4}\right)\right] = \cosh\left[(2m+1)\frac{\pi}{4}\right].$$

Hence

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(x,0.25) = \frac{16}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=0}^{\infty}\frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3}\left[1-\frac{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/4]}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Phi(x,0.25) = \frac{16}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=0}^{\infty}\frac{\sin[(2m+1)\pi x]}{(2m+1)^3}\left[1-\frac{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/4]}{\cosh[(2m+1)\pi/2]}\right].}$$

Qualitative comparison

Both the exact and variational solutions vanish at

$$x = 0, \qquad x = 1,$$

and both are symmetric about

$$x = \frac{1}{2}.$$

The variational result is simply a parabola in x for each fixed y:

$$x(1-x).$$

So it gives the correct boundary behavior and the correct symmetry, but it cannot reproduce all the detailed curvature of the exact Fourier-series solution.

At the midpoint $x = 1/2$:

For $y = 0.5$,

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi\left(\frac{1}{2}, 0.5\right) = \frac{5\pi}{4} \cdot \frac{1}{4} = \frac{5\pi}{16}.$$

For $y = 0.25$,

$$4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi\left(\frac{1}{2}, 0.25\right) = \frac{15\pi}{16} \cdot \frac{1}{4} = \frac{15\pi}{64}.$$

So the variational approximation predicts the maximum values

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi\left(\frac{1}{2}, 0.5\right) = \frac{5\pi}{16}, \qquad 4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi\left(\frac{1}{2}, 0.25\right) = \frac{15\pi}{64}.}$$

These provide convenient reference values for comparison with the exact series.

Thus the final variational solution is

$$\boxed{\Psi(x,y) = \frac{5}{4\varepsilon_0}\, x(1-x)\, y(1-y),}$$

or equivalently

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x,y) = 5\pi\, x(1-x)\, y(1-y).}$$

And for the requested slices:

$$\boxed{4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x, 0.5) = \frac{5\pi}{4}x(1-x), \qquad 4\pi\varepsilon_0\Psi(x, 0.25) = \frac{15\pi}{16}x(1-x).}$$

9 Problem 1.5

9.1 Problem Statement

The time-averaged potential of a neutral hydrogen atom is given by

$$\Phi(r) = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r}\left(1 + \frac{\alpha r}{2}\right),$$

where q is the magnitude of the electronic charge, and $\alpha^{-1} = a_0/2$, a_0 being the Bohr radius. Find the distribution of charge (both continuous and discrete) that will give this potential and interpret your result physically.

9.2 Solution

We are given a spherically symmetric potential,

$$\Phi(r) = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r}\left(1 + \frac{\alpha r}{2}\right).$$

Since the potential depends only on r, the corresponding charge distribution must also be spherically symmetric.

The relation between potential and charge density is Poisson's equation:

$$\nabla^2\Phi = -\frac{\rho}{\varepsilon_0}.$$

Therefore our task is to compute $\nabla^2\Phi$, identify any delta-function piece at the origin, and then read off the continuous and discrete parts of the charge distribution.

Step 1: Separate the potential into simpler pieces

Write

$$\Phi(r) = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left(\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} + \frac{\alpha}{2}e^{-\alpha r}\right).$$

So it is enough to know the Laplacian of the two functions

$$\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} \qquad \text{and} \qquad e^{-\alpha r}.$$

For a spherically symmetric function $f(r)$,

$$\nabla^2 f = \frac{1}{r^2}\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(r^2\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}r}\right), \qquad r \neq 0.$$

However, for functions behaving like $1/r$ near the origin, one must also include the distributional identity

$$\nabla^2\left(\frac{1}{r}\right) = -4\pi\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}).$$

More generally,

$$\boxed{\nabla^2\left(\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r}\right) = \alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} - 4\pi\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r})}$$

which is the Yukawa-potential identity.

We will also compute

$$\nabla^2(e^{-\alpha r}).$$

Step 2: Compute $\nabla^2(e^{-\alpha r})$

Let

$$f(r) = e^{-\alpha r}.$$

Then

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}r} = -\alpha e^{-\alpha r}.$$

Hence

$$r^2\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}r} = -\alpha r^2 e^{-\alpha r}.$$

Differentiate:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(r^2\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}r}\right) = \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(-\alpha r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\right).$$

Using the product rule,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\right) = 2re^{-\alpha r} - \alpha r^2 e^{-\alpha r},$$

so

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(-\alpha r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\right) = -\alpha\left(2re^{-\alpha r} - \alpha r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\right).$$

Thus

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}r}\left(r^2\frac{\mathrm{d}f}{\mathrm{d}r}\right) = -2\alpha re^{-\alpha r} + \alpha^2 r^2 e^{-\alpha r}.$$

Divide by r^2:

$$\nabla^2(e^{-\alpha r}) = -\frac{2\alpha}{r}e^{-\alpha r} + \alpha^2 e^{-\alpha r}, \qquad r \neq 0.$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\nabla^2(e^{-\alpha r}) = \alpha^2 e^{-\alpha r} - \frac{2\alpha}{r}e^{-\alpha r} \qquad (r \neq 0).}$$

Step 3: Compute the Laplacian of the full potential

Now

$$\Phi(r) = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left(\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} + \frac{\alpha}{2}e^{-\alpha r}\right),$$

so

$$\nabla^2\Phi = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left[\nabla^2\left(\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r}\right) + \frac{\alpha}{2}\nabla^2(e^{-\alpha r})\right].$$

Substitute the identities above:

$$\nabla^2\Phi = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left[\alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} - 4\pi\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) + \frac{\alpha}{2}\left(\alpha^2 e^{-\alpha r} - \frac{2\alpha}{r}e^{-\alpha r}\right)\right].$$

Distribute the factor $\alpha/2$:

$$\nabla^2\Phi = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left[\alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} - 4\pi\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) + \frac{\alpha^3}{2}e^{-\alpha r} - \alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r}\right].$$

The two $1/r$ terms cancel:

$$\alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} - \alpha^2\frac{e^{-\alpha r}}{r} = 0.$$

So the result simplifies drastically:

$$\nabla^2\Phi = \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left[-4\pi\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) + \frac{\alpha^3}{2}e^{-\alpha r}\right].$$

Therefore, from Poisson's equation,

$$\rho(\mathbf{r}) = -\varepsilon_0\nabla^2\Phi,$$

we obtain

$$\rho(\mathbf{r}) = -\varepsilon_0\frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0}\left[-4\pi\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) + \frac{\alpha^3}{2}e^{-\alpha r}\right].$$

Cancel ε_0:

$$\rho(\mathbf{r}) = -\frac{q}{4\pi}\left[-4\pi\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) + \frac{\alpha^3}{2}e^{-\alpha r}\right].$$

Distribute the minus sign:

$$\rho(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) - \frac{q\alpha^3}{8\pi}e^{-\alpha r}.$$

Hence the charge distribution is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) - \frac{q\alpha^3}{8\pi}e^{-\alpha r}.}$$

This already displays the answer in the required form: there is a discrete point charge at the origin, and a continuous negative charge cloud surrounding it.

Step 4: Identify the discrete and continuous parts

The discrete part is

$$\boxed{\rho_{\text{disc}}(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}).}$$

This is a point charge $+q$ at the origin, which is the proton.

The continuous part is

$$\boxed{\rho_{\text{cont}}(\mathbf{r}) = -\frac{q\alpha^3}{8\pi}e^{-\alpha r}.}$$

This is the spherically symmetric electronic charge cloud.

Step 5: Check that the total charge is zero

Because the hydrogen atom is neutral, the total charge should vanish. Let us verify that.

The total discrete charge is simply

$$Q_{\text{disc}} = q.$$

The total continuous charge is

$$Q_{\text{cont}} = \iiint \rho_{\text{cont}}\, d\tau = \int_0^\infty \left(-\frac{q\alpha^3}{8\pi} e^{-\alpha r}\right) 4\pi r^2\, dr.$$

Thus

$$Q_{\text{cont}} = -\frac{q\alpha^3}{2} \int_0^\infty r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\, dr.$$

Now use the standard integral

$$\int_0^\infty r^2 e^{-\alpha r}\, dr = \frac{2}{\alpha^3}.$$

Therefore

$$Q_{\text{cont}} = -\frac{q\alpha^3}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{\alpha^3} = -q.$$

So

$$Q_{\text{tot}} = Q_{\text{disc}} + Q_{\text{cont}} = q - q = 0,$$

as required.

Step 6: Relation to the hydrogen ground-state charge cloud

Since

$$\alpha^{-1} = \frac{a_0}{2}, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \alpha = \frac{2}{a_0},$$

the continuous charge density becomes

$$\rho_{\text{cont}}(r) = -\frac{q}{8\pi}\left(\frac{2}{a_0}\right)^3 e^{-2r/a_0} = -\frac{q}{\pi a_0^3} e^{-2r/a_0}.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) - \frac{q}{\pi a_0^3} e^{-2r/a_0}.}$$

This is exactly the familiar charge distribution for the time-averaged hydrogen atom in the ground state: a point proton at the origin plus the smeared-out electron charge density

$$\rho_e(r) = -\frac{q}{\pi a_0^3} e^{-2r/a_0}.$$

Physical interpretation

The potential is not simply the Coulomb potential of a point charge because the atom is not a bare proton. Instead, it consists of:

- a *positive point charge* $+q$ at the origin, representing the proton;
- a *negative continuous charge cloud* whose density decreases exponentially with r, representing the electron probability cloud in the $1s$ state.

Near the origin, the potential behaves approximately like

$$\Phi(r) \sim \frac{q}{4\pi\varepsilon_0} \frac{1}{r},$$

because very close to the origin the proton dominates.

Far from the atom,

$$e^{-\alpha r} \to 0,$$

so the potential falls off exponentially to zero rather than as $1/r$. This reflects the fact that the total charge is zero: at large distances the positive nuclear charge is screened by the negative electron cloud.

Therefore the given potential corresponds physically to a neutral hydrogen atom whose time-averaged charge distribution is

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) - \frac{q\alpha^3}{8\pi}e^{-\alpha r}}$$

or, using $\alpha = 2/a_0$,

$$\boxed{\rho(\mathbf{r}) = q\,\delta^3(\mathbf{r}) - \frac{q}{\pi a_0^3}e^{-2r/a_0}.}$$